

30 Glorious Years

3 decades of India's most stable State Government.



▲ Chief Minister Buddhadev Bhattacharya with Ratan Tata

On the 21st of June, the longest day of the year, West Bengal celebrated one of its most historic days. The country's longest serving state government is now a glorious 30 years old, and that is no mean feat. The best part is, West Bengal is not resting on its laurels. The amount of progress the state has made since the Left Front government came to power in 1977 is for all to see. The country's largest producer of rice is also now a preferred IT destination in India, it has some of the best heritage and historical tours on offer in the state, and its industrialization drive is a success story for all to see.

The state formulated its industrialization policy as early as 1994, and since then, the government has been actively wooing investment in the state.

The drive began to bear fruit during the late 1990s and the new millennium, under the chief ministership of Jyoti Basu and Buddhadeb Bhattacharya respectively. In 1994, the then chief

minister Jyoti Basu announced an overhaul of the state's infrastructure to revive ailing industries. For the first time in the post-liberalisation era, the CPI(M) government showed a willingness to accept the imperatives of privatisation when it privatised the loss-making Great Eastern Hotel.

Later, post-2000, West Bengal caught up with the southern states in the IT bandwagon. IT is now one of its key sectors. IT projects in the state took off when the fifth Left government was in power. Bhattacharya's attempts bore fruit when software giants like Wipro, IBM, TCS decided to set up shop in West Bengal. The Sector V, Bengal's IT hub, has generated thousands of employment opportunities for the state's youth, and its unemployment problems are a thing of the past. Moreover, the state boasts the lowest attrition rate among all metros in India, at 15 percent compared to 30% and 40% in Bangalore and Delhi respectively. More and more companies are joining the sector in the state, with every major multinational IT giant - from PriceWater House Coopers, HSBC, HCL, Atos Origin, Skytech, Siemens, and a host of others - setting up office here. IT still remains at the top in the state's industrial resurgence. Now, the state is developing more and more IT hubs in small cities. Siliguri, Durgapur, Kharagpur and Haldia are next in line after Sector V, and their advantage is that they are all on the Golden Quadrilateral, and are also well-connected through railways.

West Bengal has also emerged as a hardware destination. Xenitis, in collaboration with Unitech China, has already started a manufacturing unit in West Bengal, this being the first Sino-Indian joint venture in Hardware.

Videocon has also decided to manufacture computers in Kolkata.

And petrochemicals is the other success story the state can boast of. The total investment in this sector in the past five years till 2006, has been Rs 13,505 crore and growing. Haldia Petrochemicals itself has put in Rs 8,000 crore, while